MODULE 36 · FOUNDATIONS AND EXAM SKILLS - ALL DOMAINS

Exam mechanics

Time and scoring, question formats, what you can and can't return to, Microsoft Learn in the exam, and a pacing plan.

DOMAIN Exam skills WEIGHT - MODULE 36 of 39

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Mechanics don't add knowledge. They protect the marks your knowledge has **already earned**.

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Time, questions and scoring

FACT	DETAIL
Appointment	Plan for 120 minutes: 100 answering, 20 for admin
Questions	Most exams have 35 to 50; the count varies by attempt
Score range	1 to 1,000, reported as a scaled score
Pass mark	700, which is not the same as 70 percent
Wrong answers	No penalty; a blank scores the same as a wrong guess
Multi-part questions	One point per correct component: all, some or none

ON THE EXAM

Because the score is scaled, harder question sets need fewer raw points. Comparing raw counts between attempts tells you little.

Never leave a blank. A guess and a wrong answer score the **same**, and a guess can only **help**.

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What you can and can't return to

- Most questions can be **marked for review** and revisited before you leave the section.
- **Some questions can't be returned to at all.** Microsoft warns: don't skip them.
- **Case study** questions stay reviewable **until you leave that case or section**.
- Taking a **break locks** every question you've already seen, answered or not.
- Breaks aren't allowed inside labs or problem-solution question sets.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The five-minute unscheduled break is real, but it costs you every open question behind you. Finish a section first.

The question types to expect

FORMAT	WHAT TO WATCH
Single choice	One answer; eliminate rather than hunt for the perfect one
Multi-select	'Each correct answer presents part of the solution': pick the stated number
Drag and drop, build list	Order matters; partial credit per correct placement
Hotspot and dropdowns	Several sub-answers in one question, each worth a point
Problem and solution sets	The same scenario repeated, each judged alone; no going back
Case studies	A scenario with several questions; requirements decide the answers

ON THE EXAM

Multi-part formats are where partial credit lives. Answer every part, even the ones you're unsure of.

The format that catches people

- The **same scenario** appears several times, each with a different proposed solution.
- Judge each one **independently**: does this solution meet the stated goal?
- **More than one** solution may work. Or **none** may.
- You **can't return** to earlier questions in the set once you move on.
- Re-read the goal each time. It's identical, and that's exactly what makes people skim it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Seeing a better solution later doesn't make an earlier correct one wrong. Each is scored on its own.

Reading a case study efficiently

- Read the **requirements** first: technical, business, and anything labelled 'must'.
- Then read the questions. Then go back for the details they need.
- The scenario stays available, so don't memorise it.
- Requirements usually name the answer: 'no data may leave the region', 'no keys', 'minimal changes'.
- Finish every question in the case before moving on. You can't come back.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Case studies reward the same reading skill this course has drilled: find the constraint that eliminates options.

You can look things up

- Role-based and specialty exams include a **Microsoft Learn button**, in a split screen.
- AI-103 is an associate role-based exam, so this applies.
- Everything on learn.microsoft.com is available **except Q&A and your profile**.
- The **exam timer keeps running** while you read.
- Microsoft's guidance: for look-ups, **not** for answering every question.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Fundamentals exams don't include it, and it isn't in the exam sandbox, so practise searching Learn beforehand.

What to look up, and what not to

- **Worth looking up:** exact limits, retirement dates, parameter names, role names.
- **Not worth looking up:** which service fits a scenario. That's judgement, and it's slow to research.
- Know the **page names** in advance: model retirements, quotas and limits, skills reference.
- Budget **two or three look-ups** for the whole exam, not one per question.
- Looking up something you already know is how candidates run out of time.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A look-up costs two or three minutes. That's two or three questions you then answer in a hurry.

A plan for 100 minutes

PHASE	PLAN
First pass	About 2 minutes a question; answer everything, mark the doubtful
Case studies	Read requirements, then questions; finish the case before leaving
Problem-solution sets	Judge each independently; never skip, you can't return
Second pass	Revisit marked questions in the current section only
Last 10 minutes	Check nothing is blank; submit comments if you want

ON THE EXAM

Two minutes a question is the average, not the target. Simple questions should take 30 seconds and buy time for hard ones.

Scores and retakes

- You get a **scaled score** and a **domain-level breakdown**, not a list of wrong answers.
- Fail once: retake after **24 hours**. After that: **14 days** between attempts.
- Maximum **five attempts** in 12 months from the first attempt.
- You can schedule up to **90 days ahead**, and hold two exam bookings at a time.
- Use the domain breakdown to choose what to restudy, rather than re-reading everything.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A near miss usually means one or two weak domains, not a weak candidate. The breakdown shows which.

> Twenty minutes in, a candidate meets a question about a service they barely studied. Two options look plausible, and they can eliminate one.
>
> They want to come back to it later, when their head is clearer.

What should they do?

A Leave it blank and move on, so the score isn't affected by a wrong guess.

B Spend five more minutes reasoning it out before moving on to question ten.

C Answer with their best option, mark it for review, and move on.

D Open Microsoft Learn and research the service until they're confident.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should they do?

A Leave it blank.

A blank scores the same as a wrong answer, and forfeits a free chance.

B Five more minutes.

Spends 2.5 questions' worth of time on one uncertain answer.

C Best option, mark, move on.

Banks a real chance of the mark, and keeps the option to revisit.

D Research it in Learn.

Costly early on, and 'which service fits' is judgement, not a look-up.

THE SIGNAL

Answer, mark, move. It protects the mark whether or not you get back to it.

> A candidate answers a question proposing one solution to a scenario, and says it meets the goal. The next question shows the same scenario with a different solution, which looks better.
>
> They want to go back and change their earlier answer.

What should they do?

A. Judge this solution on its own merits; the earlier answer stands.

B. Answer 'no' here, since only one solution in a set can be correct.

C. Use the review screen at the end to revisit the earlier question.

D. Take the unscheduled break, then return to the earlier question refreshed.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should they do?

A Judge independently.

Each solution is scored alone, and more than one can meet the goal.

B Answer 'no' for uniqueness.

Invents a rule: sets can have several correct solutions, or none.

C Review screen later.

These sets can't be returned to once you move on.

D Break, then go back.

Breaks are blocked inside these sets, and would lock earlier questions anyway.

THE SIGNAL

'Better' doesn't mean 'the other one was wrong'. Each question asks only whether this solution meets the goal.

> A question hinges on the exact maximum number of documents allowed per request for a Language feature. The candidate knows the concept, but not the number.
>
> They have 45 minutes left and 14 questions remaining.

What's the best move?

A Guess between the two plausible numbers and move on immediately.

B Skip the question, and use the remaining time on questions they know.

C Open a phone browser quickly, since only the exam window is monitored.

D Use the Microsoft Learn button to check the documented limit.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What's the best move?

A Guess immediately.

Reasonable if time were short, but there's room for one look-up here.

B Skip it.

A blank scores zero, and the question may not be returnable.

C Phone browser.

Prohibited, and grounds for invalidating the exam.

D Microsoft Learn button.

Allowed on role-based exams, and a documented limit is exactly the right look-up.

THE SIGNAL

Learn access exists for precisely this: a single documented fact, with time in hand.

> With 12 minutes left, a candidate has 9 questions unanswered, including one long case-study question they find difficult.
>
> They also have three earlier questions marked for review in the current section.

How should they spend the time?

A Work carefully through the case study first, then whatever time allows.

B Answer all nine quickly, then revisit marked questions if time remains.

C Revisit the three marked questions first, since those answers are nearly right.

D Take the five-minute break to refocus, then work through the remainder.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should they spend the time?

A Case study first.

The hardest, longest question consuming the time nine answers need.

B Answer all nine, then revisit.

Nine zero-scoring blanks become nine real chances; marked answers already score.

C Marked questions first.

Improves answers that already have a chance, while blanks stay at zero.

D Take a break.

Costs five of twelve minutes, and locks every question already seen.

THE TIEBREAKER

Unanswered questions are worth more than improved ones. Blanks are guaranteed zeros.

Mechanics in five lines

- **100 minutes of answering, 35 to 50 questions, 700 to pass** on a scaled score.
- **Never leave a blank.** No penalty means a guess is free.
- **Some questions can't be revisited**, and a break locks everything behind you.
- **Microsoft Learn is available** on this exam. Use it for facts, not for judgement.
- **Blanks before improvements** when time runs short.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Next, modules 37 to 39: three practice exams, 20 questions each, domain-weighted and mixed.